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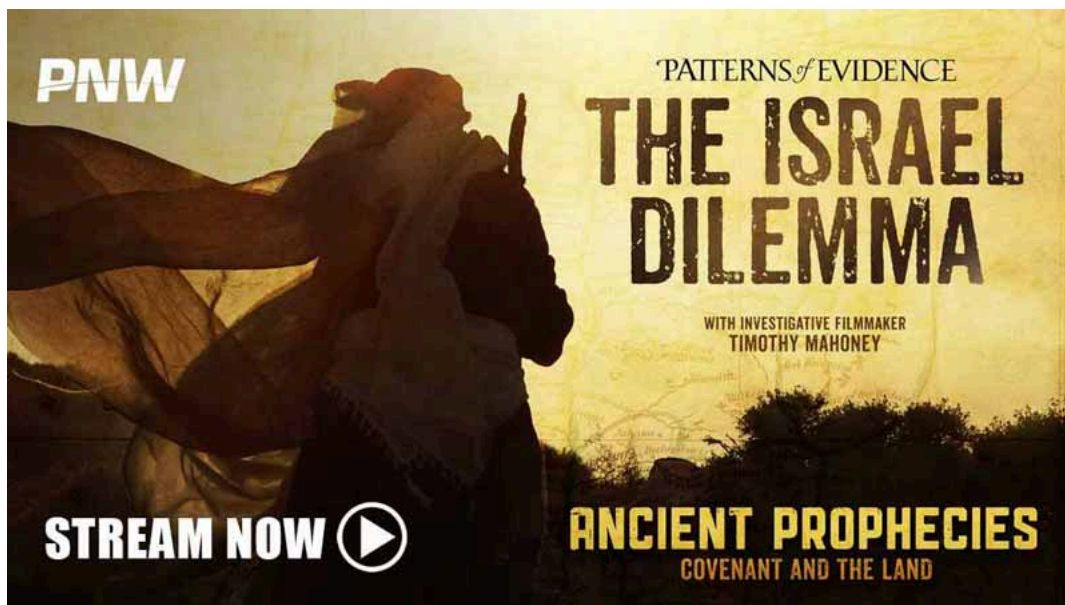
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ARTICLE

Canadian Bill Puts Bible In The Crosshairs: Sermons Could Become A Hate Crime?





BY PNW STAFF JUNE 09, 2026

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For generations, Canadians have enjoyed a reputation for being among the freest people in the world. Freedom of speech, freedom of religion, and the ability to openly debate moral and social issues have long been considered foundational rights. That is why the advancement of Bill C-9 through Canada's Senate has generated such intense concern among Christian leaders, constitutional experts, and faith communities across the nation.

Supporters of the legislation argue that it is necessary to combat hatred and protect vulnerable groups from targeted abuse. Few would dispute the importance of protecting citizens from violence, harassment, or genuine threats. The concern, however, is not whether hatred should be opposed. The concern is whether the government is redefining biblical beliefs themselves as hateful.

At the center of the controversy is Bill C-9's removal of Section 319(3)(b) of Canada's Criminal Code. That provision has historically protected individuals who express religious beliefs in good faith based on sacred texts such as the Bible. Critics warn that removing this safeguard creates a legal environment where long-held Christian teachings could become vulnerable to criminal complaints.

The legislation is now headed back to the House Of Commons where it is expected to clear Parliament and become law before the summer recess.

Many Christians are asking a simple question: What happens next?

The answer is that no
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Consider a pastor preaching through Romans 1, where the Apostle Paul describes same-sex relationships as sinful. For two thousand years, this has been a standard Christian teaching shared by the Christian church. Under previous protections, a pastor could confidently teach that passage knowing the law recognized the legitimacy of religious expression.

Under the new framework, critics fear that a complaint could be filed claiming such preaching promotes hatred against a protected group.

Perhaps the complaint would ultimately fail. Perhaps charges would never be laid. But even an investigation can become punishment. Churches could face legal expenses, reputational attacks, media scrutiny, and pressure to self-censor.

This is how speech restrictions often evolve—not necessarily through dramatic arrests, but through intimidation.

Imagine a Christian school teaching students that marriage is between one man and one woman. A teacher quotes Jesus' words from the Gospel of Matthew. A parent objects and files a complaint. Suddenly administrators must consult lawyers, revise policies, and determine whether biblical instruction exposes them to liability.

Even if the school eventually prevails, the message to other institutions becomes clear: avoid controversy, soften doctrine, and stay silent.

The chilling effect becomes the real victory.



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Christian Counseling and Pastoral Care

Another area of concern involves Christian counselors, pastors, and church leaders who provide spiritual guidance. Imagine a young adult seeking advice from a pastor regarding questions about sexuality, gender identity, or biblical morality. If the pastor responds by explaining traditional Christian teachings and encouraging the individual to align his or her life with those beliefs, critics worry that such conversations could eventually become the subject of complaints.

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Employment Standards and Church Leadership

Many churches require pastors, elders, youth leaders, and ministry staff to affirm statements of faith and live according to the church's understanding of biblical morality. Critics of Bill C-9 fear that maintaining such standards could become increasingly difficult if traditional Christian beliefs are portrayed as hateful or discriminatory.

Consider a church that requires youth leaders to affirm biblical teachings regarding marriage and sexuality. A rejected volunteer or former employee could potentially file a complaint alleging that such standards promote hatred toward a protected group. Even if the church eventually prevailed, it could face significant legal costs, public controversy, and pressure to abandon long-standing doctrinal requirements.

For many believers, the concern is not merely whether churches would win such cases. The concern is whether years of investigations, legal battles, and public scrutiny would gradually pressure Christian institutions to soften or abandon biblical convictions in order to avoid conflict altogether.

Another practical concern involves online ministry. Many Canadian pastors now reach thousands of people through YouTube, Facebook, podcasts, and livestreams. If authorities begin viewing certain biblical teachings as potentially hateful, online content could become a prime target.

Will pastors begin avoiding certain passages altogether?

Will ministries remove sermons from their archives?

Will Christian publishers stop printing books that address controversial moral issues?

These questions may sound alarmist to some, but similar patterns have already emerged in parts of Europe where speech laws have increasingly collided with religious expression.

The deeper issue extends beyond homosexuality.

Once government authorities gain greater power to determine which religious beliefs are acceptable, every unpopular biblical doctrine becomes vulnerable. Christian teaching on gender, marriage, sexual morality, exclusivity of salvation through Christ, and even certain pro-life arguments could eventually come under scrutiny.

The problem is not merely what today's government believes. Governments change. Cultural standards change. What one administration considers protected speech, another may classify as harmful expression.

Christians understand this principle because church history is filled with examples.

Throughout history, governments have often tolerated Christianity until biblical teaching collided with prevailing social values. The conflict rarely begins with a direct ban on Christianity. Instead, authorities typically insist that believers may continue worshiping privately so long as they refrain from publicly expressing certain convictions.

That distinction matters.

Freedom of worship i

Freedom of worship means Christians can gather inside church buildings and conduct services. Freedom of religion means believers can live out and proclaim their faith in public life without fear of government punishment.

Many critics argue that Bill C-9 pushes Canada closer toward the former model while weakening the latter.

Even Alberta Premier Danielle Smith has voiced concerns about authorities monitoring church services. Such warnings would have seemed unthinkable in Canada only a few years ago. Yet they are now being discussed openly by elected officials.

For Canadian Christians, the response should not be panic, but preparation.

Churches should educate congregations about their constitutional rights. Ministries should seek competent legal counsel. Christian organizations should strengthen partnerships with religious liberty groups prepared to challenge unconstitutional applications of the law.

Most importantly, believers should resist the temptation to retreat into silence.

The New Testament was written largely by men who lived under governments hostile to Christian teaching. The apostles repeatedly affirmed that believers must speak truth with both courage and love, even when doing so carries personal cost.

Christians should never use the Bible as a weapon to demean or mistreat others. Genuine hatred has no place in Christian witness. At the same time, Christians cannot abandon biblical truth simply because society increasingly labels it offensive.

That is the tension Bill C-9 brings into sharp focus.

The coming years may determine whether Canada continues to protect robust religious freedom or moves toward a model where certain biblical convictions are tolerated only when kept private. For many believers, this debate is no longer merely political or legal.

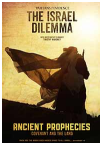
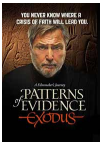
It is becoming a test of whether Christians will remain free to openly proclaim what they believe God has already spoken.

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